

than 5K and that also have a bitrate higher than 256 kbps.

The Autofill settings on the same page are self-explanatory once you know what Autofill is. So what is Autofill? It's a cool little feature that leaves you wondering what'll end up on your portable music player! When your music device is synced with Winamp, the Winamp Media Library will sometimes transfer some songs to and from the device. From the device is OK, you can expect that—but what's interesting is that it also transfers songs *to* the device without telling you! The settings here include options that control the transfer—leave them untouched if you really want a surprise the next time you press Play on your iPod. Otherwise, you can choose to, for example, transfer only high-rated songs to the device.

### Metadata And More

The Media Library holds all your music—rather, it keeps track of your collection. From the menu on the left, you can bookmark items just like in a browser, view recently played and most-played items, and so on. At the top, you can search for items in the library. Here, explore the “Metadata reading settings,” even though it's been reported to be buggy (as of now). This is a button at the bottom of the Watch Folders tab. Metadata is added to files by certain programs, for example iTunes, and is basically information about the file such as album and length and so on. Once you press Configure, the options are self-explanatory—you can, for example, choose to “smartly” detect metadata such as track number, artist and title. This, again, is useful when you have too large a music collection, and don't want to go through each song and manually look at what it is. So if you've synced with someone else's iPod, Winamp can display song information you haven't even entered!

### Going To Where You Want

“Jump To File”—also under General Preferences—can be very confusing, with its horrendous number of options. This is an implementation of the JTFE plugin, whose function is to allow you to queue your files to play in an order you specify. There are two methods to achieve this, and

a third method “is being worked on.” The first is “Enqueue,” and the second is “Move after current...” This latter places the selected file(s) after the currently playing file. For example, under Jump To File > Enqueue Options, you have “Double-click mode”: use this to specify whether double-clicking a song will play it (removing everything else in the playlist), move it to after the currently playing song, or simply enqueue it.

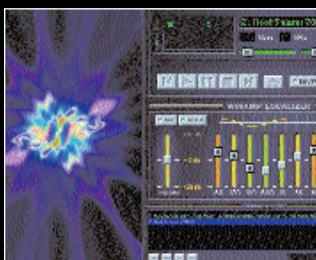
The “third method being worked on” will allow you to enqueue files to play at a given time, with the ability to control when they will be played—based on options such as day of week. It gets exotic: there will be the ability to add a “virtual file” into a “timed queue,” which will allow you to close Winamp and/or the system at a given time.

In our opinion, the JTFE plugin has been overdone—there are too many options. However, it can be useful if you have an extremely large music collection. Visit <http://nunzioweb.com/daz/jtfe.html> for more information on the plugin.

### Buffering, Fading, Silence

Under Plug-ins > Input, look at Nullsoft MPEG Audio Decoder 3.5. This is what decodes your MP3s. The first tab lists “Full file buffering”; set this to a high value if you want your MP3s to get into RAM and play from there. This is useful if you have a lot of RAM, and have no patience with the tiniest amount of skipping. Then there's the option between logarithmic and linear for the equaliser. “Logarithmic” (the default) is the opposite of “exponential,” and means that increasing a certain frequency boosts it by a *reasonable* amount. Setting it to linear will enable more drastic playing around with the equaliser settings.

If you want songs to play continuously without a gap, here's a way: go to Plug-ins > Output > DirectSound output, and click Configure. What you need to change is the “Buffer-Ahead on track change.” If you set the Buffer-Ahead to 5000 ms, Winamp will begin reading the



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next track when the current track has five seconds left, allowing for a seamless transition. But if your computer is low on memory, you're better off leaving this setting at the default.

Another interesting setting here is Fading, in the Fading tab. It's irritating to have a song end abruptly, and you can control that here. There are too many options for us to discuss here, but suffice it to say that you can control every aspect of fading you can think of—including whether or not to fade while you're seeking!

The options under Other in DirectSound output are interesting. Here you'll be able to remove the silence at the beginning or ending of tracks—and you can specify what Winamp interprets as silence. You can choose to have the volume control behave in a smooth manner (great if you don't want a song to blast you off your chair when it starts), and you can choose between a logarithmic and a linear volume control.

### SHOUTcast, Skins, Etc

If you like Internet radio, remember that Winamp has SHOUTcast support, and can ably act as your SHOUTcast client. SHOUTcast is free radio—visit [www.shoutcast.com](http://www.shoutcast.com): there's all the genres you can think of, and when you click on a result with Winamp on, it just plays! You can be a broadcaster as well—just check the documentation on the main page for details. Of course, you can also use other media players to listen to SHOUTcast streams.

There are lots and lots of skins and plugins available at [winamp.com](http://winamp.com), and new ones keep coming out. Keep checking the site to find what interests you. Then, consider DFX 7.5 for Winamp ([www.fxsound.com/dfx/](http://www.fxsound.com/dfx/)), which really makes your MP3s sound *much* better on Winamp—you won't believe your ears! At \$19.99 (Rs 900), we think it's worth it. And finally, if you're rich, consider going Pro. There isn't much of a value add except for ripping and encoding features, including ripping to AAC and WMA, but for \$19.95 (Rs 895), you'll be supporting development of the world's favourite media player! ■

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